Teaching Statement

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1 Background

My first teaching experience was tutoring math in high school, where I discovered how rewarding and fun teaching could be. After college, I spent three semesters as a lecturer at the University of Costa Rica, teaching Introduction to Economics to non-economists. That experience remains one of the happiest periods of my life and was an important input in my decision to pursue a PhD. At UCSD, I have served as an instructional assistant for more than 15 quarters, mostly in microeconomics and in behavioral and experimental economics, though also in econometrics and conservation economics. I have also been the instructor of record for two summer courses: Econ100B, a core upper-division course condensed into four weeks, and Econ171, an elective on decisions under uncertainty that allowed me to teach the foundations of my own research.

I see teaching as a bridge between discovery and understanding: it brings knowledge to life, sparks questions that feed back into research, and allows me to share topics I am passionate about. Research, in turn, keeps my teaching current, and sharing my own work and that of leading scholars exposes students to cutting-edge ideas.

Looking ahead, I am happy to teach any introductory course, and I am particularly excited to teach intermediate and advanced microeconomics (theory and applied), econometrics, and mathematics for economists. I would also welcome the chance to teach or develop electives on behavioral and experimental economics, psychology and economics, decisions under uncertainty, and related topics.

2 What I consider the four big pillars of teaching

1. Effective knowledge transmission. I approach every new concept or relationship in three steps: an intuitive example students can relate to, the tools that formalize it, and an application to a relevant problem. I implement this through active learning, including in-class practice problems, peer discussions, collective problem-solving, and mini case studies where students take the perspective of policymakers or business managers. The idea is that students engage with each new concept rather than just listen.

For example, after we covered decision criteria under uncertainty in Econ171 (minimax, maximin, and minimax regret), we took the role of a manager launching a new product and designed a pricing policy under which all three criteria favor switching from the consumer's current product to ours. Students proposed and evaluated policies until we found one that worked. A version of this exercise, with different parameters and new follow-up questions, appeared on the midterm.

In Econ100B, 18 of the 19 students who completed the teaching evaluation agreed or strongly agreed that class sessions helped them understand the course content. Likewise, across my 2024–26 evaluations as a teaching assistant, an average of 94% of respondents ($N = 173$) agreed or strongly agreed with the learning and engagement items.

2. Focus on practical relevance. Most students are not aiming for a PhD and may not be primarily interested in academic research. This matters because we are most engaged when we can relate material to things we care about or imagine applying it, now or in the future. I encourage students to think about how the topics connect to their own interests, and I build on their ideas as far as possible to keep the content relevant to them.

Because this was a central goal when I designed Econ100B, I added two custom items to its teaching evaluation. Of the respondents, 95% agreed or strongly agreed that "the instructor effectively related the course material to real-world applications or situations outside of the classroom,"

and 90% that "the instructor maintained a balance between theoretical concepts and practical applications throughout the course."

One example comes from Econ171. After covering the theory of insurance, I illustrated the concepts with a real insurance contract: the student health insurance plan. Every time students see a doctor or nurse, that plan is at work, so understanding the copay, the coinsurance, and how these change by type of provider matters to them right away. In the final reflection, which asked students to describe three things they took away from the class, one student wrote: *"I now somewhat understand the point of some insurance fees I didn't before; deductibles and co pay (insurance). Still dont like it but makes sense"*. A student leaving my class with that thought is a gain for me.

3. Empathy. Being a student is often difficult. You are constantly tested, exposed to challenging material, and at the same time navigating the pressures of a complicated age outside the classroom. I try to recognize these struggles and respond with empathy, which does not mean lowering standards or compromising rigor. Rather, it means demanding excellence while also being mindful of students' challenges and remembering that a single kind word can make a profound difference.

In practice, this means policies that are flexible but clear, stated on the syllabus from the first day. Students can drop their two lowest quizzes, need only 80–90% of participation activities for full credit, and can submit late homework for partial credit. A higher final exam score replaces the midterm score, and students can even skip the midterm entirely without justification, moving its weight to the final. The idea is that one challenging week does not ruin a student's grade, and that students can plan around their lives outside class without having to ask for exceptions, while weighing the trade-offs of each choice.

Beyond policies, the way I interact with students counts just as much. I was a student too, and I know that teachers' words matter, whether in kindergarten or in a master's program. I received this comment in the final reflection assignment for Econ100B:

"I think the most important thing I've learned is confidence. When you mentioned in the last lecture that someone had said they hated econ during the first class, that was me. I've been lurking here because I always got very poor grades in previous economics classes. This left me feeling very confused and lacking confidence. [...] Your thorough explanations made it very easy for me to understand the content you taught. [...] Thank you for making me realize that I am not a poor student!"

I don't think this reflects an "easy" class—it was not, and grade averages aligned with historical grades for the course—but the voice of a student who felt heard and supported.

In the Econ100B teaching evaluation, all respondents agreed or strongly agreed with the item on a welcoming and supportive learning environment.

4. Joy. Teaching is performative. Like a musician or an actor, a teacher develops a presence in the classroom, and today, with so many distractions, keeping students engaged is more important than ever. My teaching model is a professor of proof-based calculus who taught as if it were the most exciting job in the world, with high energy, interactive classes, and humor. I concluded that if proof-based calculus can be made fun, anything can. In my own classes, I work in current memes and humorous remarks; when a hard concept like general equilibrium is approaching, for instance, I warn the room with a "brace yourselves." When possible, I draw graphs and diagrams on the board, which forces me to slow down and gives students a different visual stimulus than slides alone. I also make trying, rather than getting it right, the goal of participation.

Students' comments consistently mention the positive and entertaining tone of my lectures: *"He has a very funny and relatable lecturing style that makes me comfortable to answer the question or say that I don't know the answer"* (Econ142, 2025, as teaching assistant), and *"He was a very*

positive person with positive attitude which encouraged and engaged me to attend and listen in class" (Econ100B, 2024, as instructor). Both comments show what joy does in a classroom: it makes students willing to participate and to show up.

3 Assessments

My exams draw on Bloom's taxonomy, which orders cognitive skills from remembering and understanding to applying, analyzing, evaluating, and creating. Conceptual multiple-choice and fill-in-the-blank questions check that students remember and understand key ideas, short-answer questions ask them to explain and analyze qualitatively, and quantitative problems ask them to apply the formal tools. For example, a question may ask students to identify fixed and variable costs in the description of a problem they could face outside of class; I think this is as important as being able to set up an optimization problem and solve it.

However, I avoid relying exclusively on exams. They are a standard way to measure learning, but a 120-minute, in-class, closed-book exam rarely leaves room for the highest levels of the taxonomy, especially creating. Performance under those conditions can also be hurt by emotions or recent experiences, and when exams are high-stakes, they leave little room for mistakes. In Econ100B, exams were 60% of the grade: still the majority, but leaving room for quizzes, homework, and participation.

Other tasks reach those higher levels. I particularly like reflections because they ask students to create: to formulate their own question and decide which tools from class can help answer it. In Econ100B, I asked students to "find a topic you like and think how class material could help answer a question." One student identified the lack of competitive teams in the Mexican women's soccer league as a question that could be studied through producer theory and cost analysis. Another, an event organizer in an ethnic community association, said he would now look more carefully at per-participant costs to assess the cost-efficiency of their activities. I find this valuable because students apply concepts in situations that make sense to them and that I would never have thought of, since they are outside my own background. Similarly, the Econ171 presentations asked students to analyze published research: one student interested in gender read and presented part of a paper on risk aversion and gender stereotypes, clearly explaining how the paper connected the two topics.

Another type of non-exam assessment I use is low-stakes formative work, such as quizzes and homework, which prepares students for summative exams by letting them fix what they got wrong before a similar question appears on an exam. This feedback is also useful for me: when quiz results show that many students missed a concept, I revisit it at the start of the next class.

A comment on student evaluations. In Econ171, I received only 2 of 13 evaluations, too few to generate a report under university policy. This partly reflects my decision not to incentivize them: in classes as small as mine, a group incentive, such as revealing a topic on the final once the class reached a response-rate target, would have put noticeable pressure on individual students. I think my main mistake was not giving students time during lecture to complete the evaluations, as I did in Econ100B, where I left the room while they did so and 19 of 29 responded. I will keep giving students that time in class in future courses. Despite the lack of evaluations for Econ171, students' final reflections offer a record of how they assessed their own learning, though not an anonymous one.

Ultimately, my goal is not simply for students to leave my courses knowing more economics, but to leave with a greater appreciation for learning, greater confidence in their ability to reason, and a sense of how economic ideas can be useful beyond the classroom.